his style or that his books will be read differently by fans now?

"It hasn't changed my style at all; in fact, I insist that the books must adhere to my standard style," says Tripathi. "But working with other talented writers certainly helps me learn and makes me grow. In terms of process, I write a short summary (5,000-10,000 words) first and share reading materials. The co-writer prepares the first draft and I work on it. What you read as a reader is the second draft."

In 2019, the Government of India made Tripathi the director of the Nehru Centre in London, which works under ICCR or the Indian Council for Cultural Relations. This latest diplomatic avatar seems to agree with Tripathi, who speaks effusively about his work with the Centre. "There is an assumption that diplomats are those who lie well," the author says. "I think differently; diplomats are those who can speak difficult truths, but say them in a manner that the counterpart is willing to listen. Furthermore, a good diplomat should also know when silence is a good idea. I think this does come to me naturally, and I am enjoying this role."

With writers, though, there's always the carrot of future books, of course, and Tripathi is no different. "My understanding of geopolitical issues has deepened. This is particularly useful at a period in history when it appears that there will be massive geopolitical changes. I've got many non-fiction book ideas from this experience!" That's music to the ears of Tripathi's legion of fans, surely. ■

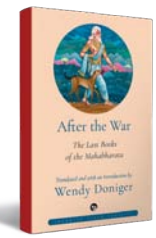
Aditya Mani Jha

BOOKS

Mastering the Myths

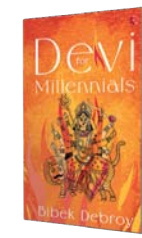
Recently released books that take inspiration from sacred Hindu texts

AFTER THE WAR: The Last Books of the Mahabharata
by Wendy Doniger
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 240 pages

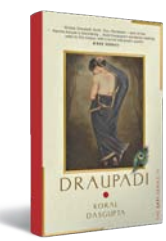


As she translates the somewhat underrated last books of the Mahabharata, Doniger uses her lucid prose to show us how the peace that followed the battle of Kurukshetra was also perilous.

DEVI FOR MILLENNIALS
by Bibek Debroy
RUPA PUBLICATIONS
₹595; 208 pages

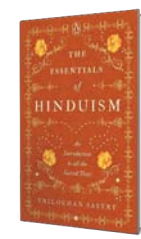


Bibek Debroy's primer both explains and demystifies the several mantras and yantras that are integral parts of Devi worship. The author also retells stories of the goddess for his curious millennial readers.



DRAUPADI
by Koral Dasgupta
PAN MACMILLAN
₹350; 226 pages

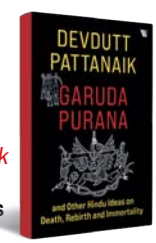
The third book of Dasgupta's five-part Sati series gives the story of Draupadi a novel spin by examining her many relationships—her marriage to the Pandavas, her friendship with Krishna, etc.



THE ESSENTIALS OF HINDUISM: An Introduction to All the Sacred Texts
by Trilochan Sastry
PENGUIN VIKING
₹499; 272 pages

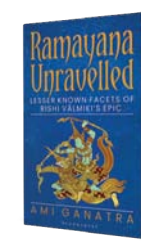
The gates of Hinduism can be opened with many keys, and Trilochan Shastry provides us entry points by way of summary. He encapsulates all ancient Hindu texts—everything from the Vedas to the epics.

Garuda Purana and Other Hindu Ideas Of Death, Rebirth And Immortality
by Devdutt Pattanaik
WESTLAND BOOKS
Rs399; 228 pages



In Hinduism, death ends one journey, but it also marks the beginning of another. Devdutt Pattanaik goes back to the *Garuda Purana* to ask, if the dead are venerable, why is death still inauspicious?

RAMAYANA UNRAVELLED: Lesser-known Facets of Rishi Valmiki's Epic
by Ami Ganatra
BLOOMSBURY
₹599; 380 pages



While revisiting the events of the Ramayana, Ami Ganatra strives to resolve some conundrums that have haunted scholars over the years: Was Ravan bad or beleaguered? Is this grand epic misogynistic?